

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles
Pentecost 10
Another Kind of Freedom ~ Kin-dom Economics
9 August 2026

COMMUNION

Preaching: ML

Worship Leading: Cynthia Siadat & LVF

Dr. Jaebon Hwang- guest organist

[Grace will need her bells table, and Piano needed for Offertory anthem, amplified]

Organ Prelude-Concert

Passacaglia in C Minor, BWV 582, Johann Sebastian Bach (1685-1750)
Pastorale on “Bunessan”, Jaebon Hwang (b. 1982)
Trio on “Ash Grove”, Jaebon Hwang
Prelude and Fugue in D Major, BWV 532, Johann Sebastian Bach

Dr. Jaebon Hwang, *Guest Organist*

Chiming of the Hour

[LVF & Cynthia center chancel]

Welcome

LVF

Words of Gathering

CS & LVF

Listen to now these words from Adrienne Marie Brown.

Be kind. Speak from the Heart.
Be principled.
Look back through time to the wound,
and forward to the medicine.
Ask curious questions when you feel
and assumption coming.
Listen to the answers

May it be so.

May it be so for all of us!

Please stand now, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering

[Choir mics on for hymn leaders]

***Hymn Of Gathering**

As We Gather at Your Table

HOLY MANNA

[Big, grand, moving along]

As we gather at your table, as we listen to your word,
help us know, O God, your presence; let our hearts and minds be stirred.
Nourish us with sacred story till we claim it as our own;
teach us through this holy banquet how to make love's victory known.

Turn our worship into witness in the sacrament of life;
send us forth to love and serve you, bringing peace where there is strife.
Give us, Christ, your great compassion to forgive as you forgave;
may we still behold your image in the world you lived to save.

Gracious Spirit, help us summon other guests to share this feast
where triumphant love will welcome those who had been last and least.
There no more will envy blind us nor will pride our peace destroy,
as we join with saints and angels to repeat the sounding joy.

[adapt/cpdawjr]

[Laura center chancel]

Prayer of Awareness

LVF

[All turn towards choir]

Introit

Let All Things Now Living
Dr. Fahad Siadat, *Conductor*, Dr. Jaebon Hwang, *Organ*

Traditional Welsh
arr. Katherine Davis

[Cynthia to lectern]

***The Lord's Prayer**

CS

Let us pray together this Lord's Prayer, adapted by enfleshed...

*Weaver of Life, Ancient and Unfolding,
How sacred is your Presence!
We lean on your guidance.
We seek your love.
We open to your transformation.
Provide us bread in body and spirit
to sustain us in faith and solidarity.
Companion us with grace
as we seek to live lives of forgiveness and compassion,
repair and accountability.
We remember those who have supported us*

*as we seek to support others
in all the mess and glory of this human journey.
Guard our minds and hearts from the temptation of domination
and turn our loyalty away from the systems of evil.
For the whole cosmos hums with your wisdom.
Everything that lives, returns to your care.
Our thanks and honor to you,
Gracious Web of Existence,
Our Source and our Home.
Amen and Amen.*

[enfleshed]

[All turn towards altar]

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

[Laura center chancel]

***Passing of the Peace**

LVF

Please join me in these words of peace:

And also with you.

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow

Please be seated

[Cynthia to lectern]

Reading from Our Religious Tradition

from the Book of Acts

CS

Hear now this reading from the Book of Acts, chapter 2...

All who believed were together and had all things in common; they would sell their possessions and goods and distribute the proceeds to all, as any had need. Day by day, as they spent much time together in the temple, they broke bread at home and ate their food with glad and generous hearts, praising God and having the goodwill of all the people.

For the witness and challenge of our ancestors...

Thanks be to God!

[Jaebon transition Laura to center chancel]

Prayers with the People

LVF

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

[2 minutes Jaebon transition out of silence]

Prayer of Our Hearts

Holy One, you are always and forever with us. You have offered us, and our ancestors before us, your life-giving presence - but we don't always respond to your invitations. The abundance of your world overwhelms us; your faithfulness surrounds us, and yet...we draw back.

You have shown us through Jesus, the humanity you hope can be ours. It all sounds so good God – freedom, justice, peace – but these things ask so much of us! And because we forget to rely on the help you offer through the Spirit of Life, we grow discouraged or indifferent...too easily. And yet, O God, we do want what you want – a new creation where we shall live, one and all, as one people.

On this day, Holy One, let this kind of newness begin with us – help us to forget what lies behind and turn our hearts and hands to what is ahead. Help us get free from the chains of guilt and self-pity, which stop our energy to love and our ability to *be* loved. Freshen up our hopes and dreams and help us make a new commitment to what lies before us.

And then, O God, bring us to a place, where we can help each other as we share in the mystery of life - and as we share the goodness of you.

*This we pray, creating with you, transforming God!
Amen and Amen.*

[Jaebon transition for Laude]

Meditation Anthem

Concord
Laude

Benjamin Britten
Text: William Plomer

*Concord is here our days to bless. And this our land to endue with plenty, peace and happiness.
Concord. Concord and Time. Each needeth each. The ripest fruit hangs where not one,
but only two. Only two can reach.*

[Jaebon transition Michael to pulpit]

Sermon

Kin-dom Economics

ML

[Jaebon transition as Michael & Laura go behind communion table]

The Eucharist and Blessings

LVF & ML

Words of Invitation and Remembrance

We give thanks to God for our life
And the courage we are given to live it.

Let our gratitude for life be expressed in our generosity.
Let our faith be expressed in good causes.
Let our belief in the future find full expression
In our daily attitude of mind. [Frances McNab]

We give thanks for the invitation to be at this table,
For here we are shown our lives...

The daily bread of work and care,
The cup of delight, pressed from the fruits of creativity
And our brokenness, with all its pain and self-knowledge.

We celebrate that life is ours
For we know we are precious in your sight.
We celebrate the life that is yours, pattern of reality for us:
Life that is love revealed
Love given and received
Love in action.

Therefore with all your lovers through the ages
We praise you, saying:
Heaven and earth are full of your glory.
Blessed are those who come in the name of
Love and Hope.

Bread and Fruit of the Vine

We give thanks for the Spirit of New Life
Active in our lives
As it was in the life of Jesus.

At this gathering in this sacred place
We take bread as Jesus took bread,
And we remember as Jesus remembered,
The constant presence
Of the Spirit of Life and Love.

We break and share this bread
As Jesus broke and shared it.

We share this bread as our pledge of openness
To the Spirit in our midst,
And in acknowledgement
Of our eternal connectedness with the Spirit of Life.

We take this fruit of the vine and pour it as Jesus poured it.

We drink as Jesus invited the friends to drink,
Mindful of the relationship of love and trust
Between ourselves and the Spirit of Life,
Believing as Jesus believed,
That beyond pain and shadows and death,
Life in the Spirit continues
In ways beyond our imagining.

LVF: This table is for all, whether you have a lot of faith, etc....

Sharing of the Bread and the Cup

At this table we celebrate all the diverse ways we have been created. Everyone is invited to share in this feast. This morning we will receive communion with gluten free wafers and grape juice. You are invited to come forward to receive these gifts and then light a candle to signify the prayers of your heart on this day. As we share this time, we remember that this is the bread of new life and the cup of hope, given in love for each of us.

**[Grace, Fahad, Brandon, Scott help set up the bells table during communion, and piano moved into place after communion]
[Cynthia to lectern]**

Invitation to Generosity

CS

Offertory

Like a River Glorious

John Mountain

Arr. Christine Anderson & John Carter

Grace Sheldon-Williams, *Bells*, Donald Brown, *Piano*

[All turn towards altar]

***Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!

Alleluia! Alleluia!

Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.

Alleluia! Alleluia!

Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!

[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

[Cynthia to lectern]

***Prayer of Offering**

CS

Holy One, through the offering of these gifts
may we become a more open people.

Help us to be more open-minded in listening for your Word and wisdom,

open-hearted in working to heal a broken world,
open-handed in giving to those in need.

*With thanks for all good gifts, we present a portion of our substance
and the whole of ourselves.*

*We offer this prayer with hope for the freedom of all.
Amen and Amen!*

Please be seated

[Michael & Laura center chancel]

Life at First Church

ML & LVF

Words of Blessing

ML

For freedom,
the Holy One has set us free!
No longer bound by fear;
Not tempted towards
destruction!
Love is our salvation and
justice is our cause.
With the Spirit as our guide,
We shall not be moved.
-enfleshed

May it be so.

May it be so for all of us!

Choral Response

Dona Nobis Pacem, *from B Minor Mass* J.S.Bach
Brandon Harris, *Conductor*, Dr. Jaebon Hwang, *Organ*
Grant Us Peace

[Choir mics on for hymn leaders]

***Hymn for the Journey**

Come, See the Fullness

BUNESSAN

God the Creator gave in abundance all of the wonder we now behold;
Colors of glory, everyday beauty, echo the story of God's deep love.

Bold as the sunlight, tender as nightfall, love shaped the heav'n's height; love filled the seas.
Love formed the flowers, called for the living; marked out the hours of time to be.

Come, see the fullness – Life we've been given; beauty and promise, mystr'y and hope.
Laughter and weeping, vision and purpose; friends for the keeping, strength for the road.

Open your hearts wide, teach us your wisdom lest our days pass by empty and small.
May we be witness with your creation – to your great kindness given to all.

[Laura center chancel]

Postlude

Fugue in G Major, “Gigue”, BWV 577, Johann Sebastian Bach

Dr. Jaebon Hwang, *Guest Organist*

Inside The Music- Dr. Ianthe Marini

Today marks the beginning of a transition in the life of our church as Dr. Fahad Siadat and I begin our roles as Co-Interim Directors of Music & Arts at the Cathedral. Within the framework of the church, I am still in my current interim role with First Kids First as Claire Kelly continues her maternity leave, as I help to organize and plan music from afar, joining the chancel again in September. On the chancel today is the beautiful reflection of collaborative efforts of community as we march on with Grace and Don on the bells and piano, both Fahad and Brandon at the choir’s helm, our guest organist Dr. Hwang while Christoph continues his much deserved time at home, and the ever-present solid foundation of our choir of professionals and faithfully committed volunteers in singing leadership. I felt that this tangible and active definition of the term *co-operation* was especially apropos to the theme of the day: *Kin-dom Economics*.

It is for this reason that I have centralized one of my favorite poems as the Meditation Anthem: William Plomer’s *Concord* which simply states, “*Concord and Time, each needeth each. The ripest fruit hangs where not one, but only two can reach.*” And isn’t this the economic structure to which we are called and that which we know most healthfully benefits all? That when *ALL things now living can celebrate in joy and thanksgiving*, as we sing in our introit, we can together enjoy *the river glorious* (as Grace illustrates through bells), and achieve the peace about which we triumphantly and proactively sing in Bach’s setting of that urgent imperative—*grant us peace* (in choral response). And in the pursuit of all these things we know: *each needeth each: the ripest fruit hangs where not one, but only two can reach.*